Mailbox full: archiving and cleaning up

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Summary

When a user's Exchange Online mailbox reaches its 50?GB quota they receive warnings, cannot send new messages, and may see bounce-backs. This article explains how to check mailbox usage, enable the online archive (if not already active), and clean up large items or old folders to bring usage below the threshold. It provides a self-help procedure for end-users and a separate workflow for Messaging & Collaboration L1 agents.

Symptoms

- "Your mailbox is over its size limit" warning in Outlook
- "Cannot send the message because the sender's mailbox is over the quota" NDR
- Mailbox usage shown as >=?49?GB in Outlook -> File -> Info -> Mailbox Settings -> View mailbox size
- Inability to create new items or receive new mail until space is freed

Common causes

- Accumulation of large attachments in Sent Items, Inbox, or custom folders
- Retention of old email beyond business need
- Deleted Items folder not emptied, consuming quota
- Online Archive not enabled or not being used for older mail

Overview

Acme Global provides each user a 50?GB primary mailbox plus an online archive that can hold additional data. When the primary mailbox approaches the limit, Outlook shows warnings and blocks sending. The online archive is automatically provisioned for most users but may need to be enabled or the user may need to move items into it. Regular housekeeping-deleting large attachments, emptying Deleted Items, and using archive policies-keeps the mailbox healthy and avoids productivity impact.

Self-Help Procedure

Follow these steps to check your mailbox size, enable the online archive if needed, and clean up large items. All actions can be performed in Outlook for Windows, Outlook for Mac, or Outlook on the web (OWA).

1. 1. **Check mailbox usage**
   - Outlook Windows/Mac: File -> Info -> Mailbox Settings -> View mailbox size.
   - OWA: Settings (gear) -> View all Outlook settings -> General -> Storage.
   Note the percentage used; if it is >=?90?% you will see warnings.
2. **Enable the online archive (if not already active)**
   - In Outlook Windows/Mac: right-click your mailbox name -> Properties -> Policy tab -> Ensure "Online Archive" is listed and status is "Enabled". If missing, contact the IT Service Desk (extension 4357) to request archive activation.
   - In OWA: Settings -> View all Outlook settings -> Mail -> Auto-processing -> Archive settings -> toggle "Use online archive" on.
3. **Move old items to the online archive**
   - Select a folder (e.g., Inbox) -> select emails older than 6?months (use Search -> Date -> Older than 6 months).
   - Right-click -> Move -> Online Archive -> Inbox (or create a matching folder).
   - Repeat for Sent Items, Drafts, and any custom folders.
4. **Find and delete large attachments**
   - Outlook Windows/Mac: Search box -> Type "hasattachment:yes" -> Click the filter "Has Attachments".
   - Sort by Size (click the Size column).
   - Select the largest items (>=?5?MB) you no longer need -> Delete (Shift+Delete to bypass Deleted Items if you are sure).
   - OWA: Use the search bar -> "hasattachment:yes" -> filter -> sort by Size.
5. **Empty Deleted Items and Junk Email**

- Right-click Deleted Items -> Empty Folder.
- Right-click Junk Email -> Delete All.

6. **Set up a retention policy (optional but recommended)**
   - Outlook Windows/Mac: File -> Tools -> Clean up old items -> Configure AutoArchive settings.
   - Or ask the Messaging & Collaboration team to apply a default retention tag that moves items older than 12?months to the online archive.
7. **Re-check usage**
   - Repeat step?1. Aim for <=?60?% usage (??30?GB) to stay comfortably below the quota and avoid future warnings.

Service Desk Procedure

When a ticket arrives with symptoms of a full mailbox, the L1 Messaging & Collaboration agent should verify the user's mailbox size, ensure the online archive is enabled, and guide the user through cleanup or perform a bulk move if authorized. The following steps outline the standard workflow.

1. 1. **Open the ticket** and confirm the user's primary SMTP address.
2. **Check mailbox size** via the Exchange admin center (EAC) or PowerShell:
   ```powershell
   Get-MailboxStatistics -Identity <user@acme.example> | Select DisplayName, TotalItemSize, ItemCount
   ```
   Record the size and percentage of the 50?GB quota.
3. **Verify online archive status**:
   ```powershell
   Get-Mailbox -Identity <user@acme.example> | FL ArchiveStatus, ArchiveGuid
   ```
   If `ArchiveStatus` is `None`, open a request with the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team to provision the archive (temporary access pass may be needed).
4. **Inform the user** of current usage and advise enabling the archive if not present.
5. **Perform a targeted move** (with user consent) for mail older than a defined period (e.g., >?12?months):
   ```powershell
   New-MailboxExportRequest -Mailbox <user> -ContentFilter "{Received -lt '01/01/2024'}" -FilePath \\exchsvr\PSTexports\<user>_old.pst
   ```
   After export, import into the online archive or delete the PST per data-retention policy.
6. **Guide the user** through the self-help steps (section above) via Teams chat or remote session, emphasizing deletion of large attachments and emptying Deleted Items.
7. **Confirm resolution**: re-run the mailbox size check; ensure usage is below 70?% (ideally <=?60?%). Update the ticket with before/after sizes and close.
8. **If the mailbox remains >?90?%** after cleanup, escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration L2 team for possible quota increase review or mailbox migration.

When to escalate

Escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration L2 team when:

- The mailbox size remains above 90?% of the 50?GB quota after the L1 agent has enabled the online archive and performed cleanup or export/import steps.
- The user requires a permanent quota increase (e.g., for a role-based exception) that exceeds the standard limit.
- There are signs of mailbox corruption or sync issues preventing normal item movement.

When escalating, include:

- User's SMTP alias and display name.
- Latest mailbox size statistics (total item size, item count, archive status).
- Summary of steps already taken (archive enabled, items moved, deletions performed).
- Any error messages encountered during PowerShell export/import or Outlook operations.
- Attach relevant screenshots or logs from the Exchange admin center or the user's Outlook client.

Keywords: mailbox full, quota exceeded, cannot send email, online archive, Outlook storage, delete large attachments, empty deleted items,

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